

Orchid

Many flowers rely on sweet nectar to attract pollinating animals. Bucket orchids are different. They are pollinated only by male euglossine bees (also known as orchid bees). The orchids attract the bees with a unique scent. When the bee visits the flowers, the blooms get pollinated—in return, the bee picks up a scent that helps it find a mate.

Treetop flower

The bucket orchid grows in nests made by ants on the branches of forest trees. The ants feed on the orchid's sweet nectar, while the plant's roots take nutrients from the nest. Soon, the orchid produces an unusually shaped flower.

Collecting scent

The scent of bucket orchid flowers attracts only euglossine bees. When a bee arrives, he collects the fragrance and stores it in special "perfume pouches" on his back legs.

The male bee recognizes the bucket orchid's unique scent.

See also

Read about how the rafflesia flower (66–67) uses its foul stink, rather than a sweet perfume, to attract flies.

Splash down

The flower's surface is slippery, and the bee soon falls into a goo-filled bowl at the flower's base. Luckily, there's an escape route—a tube just wide enough for the euglossine bee.

Wriggling out

As the bee tries to wriggle out, the tube tightens and traps him. Two packets of pollen are stuck to the bee's back, out of his reach.

